

the senses. So you might have to stop buying magazines, watching late-night TV, and mindlessly surfing the Internet at least for ninety days, until you have better control over your spending. Advertising is insidious, subliminal, and peripheral; ads are everywhere, so you can't completely cut off your exposure. But you can limit what comes into your house. So unsubscribe from those magazines, get offline more often, and don't forget to DVR your favorite TV shows. That way you can fast-forward through the commercials.

Money Mistake: Frugality Isn't Fun

THE FIX: CREATE A "FUN MONEY" FUND

If eliminating debt and saving money are priorities for you, then some measure of austerity has to be instituted. You do have to tighten your belt and keep a closer eye on your wallet. That's a given. But a certain kind of joylessness can also creep in. It happens with dieters who deprive themselves of anything fattening, decadent, or delicious in a punishing quest to reach their goal weight. You hear the stories of late-night binges triggered by weeks, months, even years of constant deprivation. That's not a way to live, and that's not what I'm advocating in these pages. Austerity, yes; deprivation, no. In fact, spending on fun things should be part of your budget. I suggest that you set aside a manageable percentage every week in a fund that will allow you to splurge with cash. Let yourself do whatever you want with that money. Buy something that gives you pleasure, go on a trip, get your hair done—as long as you pay for it outright. These are the kinds of shopping trips you get to fully and completely enjoy, guilt-free.

Cold Hard Truth Card

If you're serious about getting your finances in order, cut out this card from the book, front and back (sorry it leaves a nasty hole in your